

Complaining about the country's situation on Facebook and saying that XYZ politician is corrupt on Twitter is one thing. Being interrogated by police is totally another. Though both the things might not seem connected to each other, the fact is, they are. One of the points we hardly realize or take into account when posting content online are the laws. The most widespread idea is: "I have freedom of speech granted by the laws in the constitution". Another thought can come to mind in tandem with the first is: "Who is watching me anyway?" There are many other similar arguments that follow which help us convince that no matter what we do online we can just get away with it! Nothing can be far from the truth.

Being a responsible netizen in our time has become as important as being a responsible citizen. It is not the duty of our neighbour to warn us against online acts of profanity; it is our duty and responsibility to check those things. If only you remember the recent incident of the two girls being arrested by Mumbai police over a Facebook post, you would have realised how the online world isn't impervious real laws and how the body of law itself interprets online activities to punish offenders who don't toe the line. Of course in this case even the law was misused, but you get what we're trying to say.

It is notable that IT laws (or cyber laws) do not redefine everything. The fact is that they just define what actions taken online will be synonymous to what acts done offline. For example, if you are creating a public/open group on Facebook where you are sharing link to pirated software, then it would more or less translate into you teaching innocent people about how to loot a company building in the real world. Well, we can't tell you everything here because we do not have enough space and we're sure that the actual letter of the law does not excite most of us. So we will simplify things and put up a few guidelines, a list of dos and don'ts which you can follow to be safe online.

Every move we take online, every comment we post, every new status message, blog post, image upload everything is recorded, logged somewhere. Anything that appears publicly on this wild and largely uncontrolled medium of thought that is the internet can be tracked, if needed. The case of the Mumbai girls came into limelight due to the speed at which several steps were executed under a controversial situation. There is a possibility however, that actions could have been taken slowly and that the news would have never spurred the interest of masses the way it did.